

Malagasy carnivores

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Carnivora
FAMILY	Eupleridae
SPECIES	8

This group of carnivores includes civetlike and mongooselike carnivores combined in a single family and entirely restricted to Madagascar. They have had a long isolated evolutionary history and probably originated from African mongooselike ancestors.

Anatomy

The civetlike species are nocturnal thick-furred carnivores that include the fossa and falanouc. The former is big enough to prey on lemurs in trees and has retractile claws, like those of a cat; the latter is a smaller pointed-headed animal with large, flat feet and bushy tail. Mongooselike species are marked with body stripes, spots, or tail bands, and most have feet with various degrees of webbing.

Predators in isolation

These are the only native mammalian carnivores in Madagascar, together taking a variety of prey appropriate for their body size—ranging from earthworms and insects to mammals and birds. Most are forest dwellers and many—unlike true mongooses—are adept at climbing trees. Malagasy

CATLIKE APPEARANCE

The catlike fossa is the largest Malagasy carnivore. It hunts mainly lemurs, but it will eat almost any small animal it can catch.

“civets” are nocturnal, but the “mongooses” are mostly active during the day. They sleep in dens consisting of tree hollows or burrows.



Eupleres goudotii

Falanouc



Length 18–26 in (45.5–26 cm)
Tail 9–10 in (22–25 cm)
Weight 3¼–10 lb (1.5–4.5 kg)

Location E. and N. Madagascar

Social unit Individual
Status Near threatened



Brown on the upperparts, whitish gray on the underside, with a long, slender snout and a short, bushy tail, the falanouc inhabits the Madagascar rain forests and marshes. It uses its long front claws to dig in soil for worms, grubs, insects, slugs, snails, and rodents. The single young, born with eyes open, can follow its mother after only 2 days, and is weaned by 9 weeks. Falanoucs are threatened by habitat loss, humans, dogs, and an introduced competitor, the small Indian civet (*Viverricula indica*).



Fossa fossana

Spotted fanaloka



Length 16–18 in (40–45 cm)
Tail 8½–18 in (21–30 cm)
Weight 3¼–4½ lb (1.5–2 kg)

Location Madagascar

Social unit Pairs
Status Near threatened



Found in forests of eastern and southern Madagascar, this spotted carnivore resembles a civet—and used to be classified with them. It lacks the anal scent glands of civets—instead, it probably marks its territory using secretions from its cheek and neck. Pairs of fanalokas defend territories with a range of eerie vocalizations: they spend the day in tree hollows and venture out at night to forage in trees and on the ground for invertebrates, such as worms and crustaceans, as well as frogs, and sometimes fruit.

Salanoia durrelli

Durrell’s vontsira



Length 12–13 in (31–33 cm)
Tail 7–8½ in (17.5–21 cm)
Weight 1¼–1½ lb (600–675 g)

Location Madagascar

Social unit Individual
Status Not evaluated



This reddish brown Malagasy mongoose was described in 2010 and named after Gerald Durrell, the conservationist. It is adapted to the marshland area of Lac Alaotra in Madagascar—an important region that harbors many unique species—and has one of the smallest ranges of any carnivore. The species has been observed swimming in Lac Alaotra and it is possible that its broadly padded feet help it move around in the waterlogged habitat: specimens have been trapped on floating mats of vegetation. Here, it is likely that it feeds on crustaceans and mollusks, which it smashes with its strong teeth. It is most closely allied to the insectivorous brown-tailed mongoose of Madagascar dry forests. The long-term survival of Durrell’s vontsira is threatened by agricultural encroachment and pollution from fertilizers and pesticides.

Cryptoprocta ferox

Fossa



Length 28–32 in (70–80 cm)
Tail 26–30 in (65–75 cm)
Weight 12–19 lb (5.5–8.6 kg)

Location Madagascar

Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable



Resembling a diminutive brown “big cat,” the fossa is lithe, agile, and an excellent leaper and climber. Madagascar’s largest carnivore, this muscular, powerful predator hunts by day or night, using the stalk-and-pounce method. It originally specialized in hunting lemurs but now also takes pigs, poultry, and other domesticated animals. A top carnivore, the solitary fossa naturally has a large territory, more than 1½ square miles (4 square km), and thus a low population density. It is threatened by loss of its habitat and persecuted for its attacks on livestock.

